

Women at Work

By unlocking the hidden potential of millions of women, India can accelerate its journey to becoming a global economic powerhouse by 2047

INDIA IS CURRENTLY the fastest-growing major economy, and has a vision of becoming 'Viksit Bharat' (Developed India) by 2047. To achieve this ambitious goal, it is imperative to tap into the full potential of the female workforce. Women's participation in economic activity is not just a matter of social equity, but an economic necessity. If harnessed effectively, it could add trillions to India's GDP, drive innovation, and create a more resilient and sustainable economy. A recent World Bank study states that "gender gaps in labour force participation persist worldwide. Closing this gap can lead to sizeable gains for economies—a 20% increase in GDP per capita, on average".

Encouragingly, data over the past six years shows a positive trend in female workforce participation in the country. Indicators such as increased engagement in economic activity, a declining unemployment rate, a rising number of educated women joining the workforce, and steadily increasing earnings across employment categories paint an optimistic picture. However, despite these improvements, much remains to be done, particularly since the Union Budget 2025-26 has set an ambitious target—70% female workforce participation by 2047.

A Significant Shift

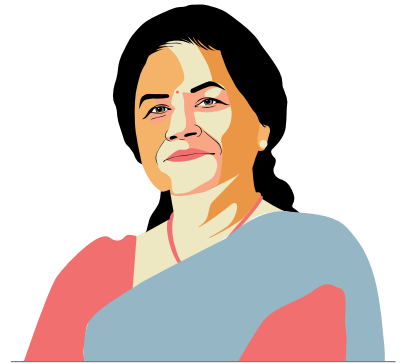
The PLFS 2023-24 reports a substantial rise in female workforce participation. The Worker Population Ratio (WPR) for women aged 15 years and

above increased to 40.3% in 2023-24 from 22% in 2017-18. Similarly, the Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR) for women in this age group rose from 23.3% in 2017-18 to 41.7% in 2023-24, while female unemployment dropped from 5.6% to just 3.2%. These figures challenge outdated claims of stagnation in female employment and indicate a remarkable transformation.

Expanding opportunities for women in economic activities such as food-processing, manufacturing, logistics, emerging tech-driven industries, and green jobs, etc, will accelerate this. A more inclusive workforce enhances productivity and innovation while improving health and education outcomes for families, leading to better child nutrition, cognitive development, and lower healthcare expenditures.

Government Interventions

To drive higher female workforce participation, the government has taken several crucial steps, such as: (i) Women's reservation in Parliament: In a historic move, India enacted one-third reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies in 2023, ensuring greater female representation in decision-making; (ii) Workplace safety and accommodation: The Working Women Hostels scheme provides safe housing for working women, enabling more women to seek employment away from home; (iii) Greater inclusion in the armed forces and law enforcement: Women are now eligible for permanent



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